NEXUS Website Tool Guide

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This guide explains the ten tools we recommend for the new NEXUS website: what each one does, why NEXUS needs it, how we will use it, and what it costs. All ten are free for what NEXUS needs. It accompanies the NEXUS Website Study.

The ten tools at a glance

#	Focus area	Tool	When it comes in	Cost
1	Protecting the old site's link value	Ahrefs Webmaster Tools	Now, before launch	Free
2	Technical SEO checks and redirect testing	Screaming Frog SEO Spider	Staging and launch	Free up to 500 URLs
3	Visibility in Google search	Google Search Console	Now, then ongoing	Free
4	Visibility in Bing and AI answers	Bing Webmaster Tools	Now, then ongoing	Free
5	Keyword and competitor research	Semrush	Before copy is finalised	Free, 10 reports a day
6	Audience research	SparkToro	Before launch	Free, 3 previews a month
7	Message clarity	Lyssna	Before copy is finalised	Free, 15 responses
8	Visitor behaviour	Microsoft Clarity	From launch	Free
9	Enquiry and conversion tracking	Google Analytics 4	From launch	Free
10	Speed and accessibility	PageSpeed Insights	Staging and launch	Free

Each account will be registered to a NEXUS-owned email address, with our team added as users, so NEXUS keeps full ownership of its data.

1. Ahrefs Webmaster Tools

Focus area: protecting the old site's link value during the move · **Cost:** free for verified sites · ahrefs.com/webmaster-tools

What it is. Ahrefs' free toolset for site owners, recently renamed "Ahrefs Free". It uses the same data as the paid Ahrefs product, limited to websites you prove you own.

Why NEXUS needs it. 884 other websites link to nexuscreativehq.com. Those links are the main reason the domain is trusted, and they point at old addresses. If an old address simply disappears, the value of its links is lost. This tool shows exactly which old pages hold links, including the ones already returning errors.

What it includes

- **Site Explorer:** every site linking to NEXUS, the pages they link to, and broken links.
- **Site Audit:** checks for more than 170 technical and on-page SEO issues, with advice on fixing each one.
- **Web Analytics:** a cookie-free traffic counter.

How we will use it

1. Verify nexuscreativehq.com, quickest by connecting Google Search Console.
2. Export the "best by links" list, including pages that now return errors, and add every address on it to the redirect map.
3. Check the quality of the linking sites, so we know which links matter most.
4. After launch, run a monthly Site Audit on the new site and check that no linked address returns an error.

Limits. It works only on websites you own: looking at competitors needs a paid plan. Site Audit has 5,000 crawl credits a month, plenty for this site, and Site Explorer shows up to 1,000 backlinks or keywords at once.

Paid upgrade. Ahrefs Lite, $129/month, adds competitor research, rank tracking and AI prompt checks, and connects directly to Claude.

2. Screaming Frog SEO Spider

Focus area: technical SEO checks and redirect testing · **Cost:** free up to 500 URLs · screamingfrog.co.uk/seo-spider

What it is. A desktop program for Windows, macOS and Linux that crawls a website the way a search engine does, then lists every page with its status, title, headings, canonical tag, redirects and broken links.

Why NEXUS needs it. Your brief's sign-off checks include unique titles and descriptions, one H1 per page, correct canonical tags, no broken links, and a single 301 redirect from every old address. This tool checks all of them in one crawl and produces reports we can hand over as evidence.

How we will use it

1. **Crawl the staging site** to find missing or duplicate titles and descriptions, pages without exactly one H1, wrong canonical tags, broken links and images without alt text.
2. **Test the redirect map:** load the full list of old addresses and confirm each returns one 301 to the right new page, with no chains or loops.
3. **Repeat on launch day** against the live domain, then again a week after launch.
4. **Keep the exports** as acceptance evidence.

Limits. The free version crawls up to 500 URLs at a time, which covers this site, but it can't save crawls or render JavaScript, and some configuration options are locked.

Paid upgrade. A licence costs £199 a year per user. It removes the limit and unlocks saved crawls, JavaScript rendering and Google integrations. NEXUS is unlikely to need it at this size.

3. Google Search Console

Focus area: visibility in Google search · **Cost:** free · search.google.com/search-console

What it is. Google's own service for website owners. It is the only source of real data on which searches show NEXUS in Google, how often, and how many people click.

Why NEXUS needs it. Your brief requires it, owned by a NEXUS account. Today NEXUS ranks for two searches, both for its own name. Search Console is where we will see whether the audience pages start appearing for searches from buyers who don't know NEXUS yet, the main SEO goal.

Reports we will use

- **Performance:** searches, clicks, impressions, click-through rate and average position, for each page and each search term.
- **Page indexing:** which pages Google has indexed, and any errors such as old addresses returning 404.
- **Sitemaps:** submitting the new sitemap and checking Google reads it.
- **URL Inspection:** asking Google to crawl a key page as soon as it goes live.
- **Core Web Vitals:** real-visitor speed data, once traffic is high enough.

How we will use it

1. Verify the domain through a DNS record now, so we have a baseline before the switchover.
2. Submit the sitemap and inspect the key pages on launch day.
3. Check daily for errors through awards week, then weekly.
4. Track searches that don't include the NEXUS name for each audience page, and report them monthly.
5. Link it to Google Analytics 4, Bing Webmaster Tools and Ahrefs, which can all import from it.

Limits. Data covers the last 16 months, and only searches on Google.

4. Bing Webmaster Tools

Focus area: visibility in Bing and AI answers · **Cost:** free · bing.com/webmasters

What it is. Microsoft's equivalent of Search Console, covering Bing search and, through its AI Performance report, Microsoft's AI answers.

Why NEXUS needs it. Your brief requires it, and asks that AI assistants describe NEXUS accurately and send the right people to the right page. Bing Webmaster Tools is currently the only free source showing when an AI assistant cites your pages. Bing is also available in mainland China, where Google is not.

The AI Performance report

- Covers citations in Microsoft Copilot, AI-generated summaries in Bing, and some partner AI services.
- **Pages:** which NEXUS pages are cited in AI answers, and how often.
- **Grounding queries:** the phrases the AI searched for when it picked your content, with your share of the citations for each.
- Exports to a spreadsheet for monthly reporting.

How we will use it

1. Add the site by importing it from Google Search Console. Data appears within about a day.
2. Submit the new sitemap at launch, and turn on IndexNow so Bing hears about new and changed pages straight away.
3. Check the AI Performance report monthly: which pages AI cites, and whether it describes NEXUS with the approved one-line description.
4. Use the grounding queries to plan Insights articles and FAQ answers.

Limits. The AI report shows citations, not clicks or visits, and it can't be filtered by AI service. It covers Microsoft's AI services only, not ChatGPT or Google's AI answers. Sources: Practical Ecommerce, Search Engine Land.

5. Semrush

Focus area: keyword and competitor research · **Cost:** free, 10 reports a day · semrush.com

What it is. One of the two leading SEO research platforms, alongside Ahrefs. It estimates how many people search for a term, how hard it is to rank for, and which websites rank for it now.

Why NEXUS needs it. Each audience page should match what its buyers actually type. For example, would an international company search "UK market entry", "expand to the UK" or "soft landing UK"? Semrush answers that with UK search volumes, and shows which consultancies, agencies and programmes already rank, so we know who NEXUS is competing with in search.

How we will use it

1. Run **Keyword Overview** on the candidate terms for each audience page, using the UK database: monthly searches, difficulty and search intent.
2. Pick one main term and two or three supporting terms per page, and pass them into the page titles, headings and copy.
3. Run **Domain Overview** on the three to five sites ranking highest for those terms, to see what they rank for and how strong they are.
4. After launch, recheck the main terms monthly.

Limits. The free account allows 10 reports a day across all tools and one project, with results capped per report. That is enough for focused checks, so we will plan each day's 10 reports in advance.

Paid upgrade. The SEO plan costs $139/month ($117.33/month billed yearly) and removes the daily cap. A version with AI search tracking costs $199/month. Semrush connects directly to Claude.

6. SparkToro

Focus area: audience research · **Cost:** free, 3 preview reports a month · sparktoro.com

What it is. An audience research tool. You describe an audience, for example people who talk about "UK market entry" or follow a particular account. It shows which websites, podcasts, YouTube channels and social accounts that audience pays attention to, and the words they use.

Why NEXUS needs it. Institutions and sponsors rarely arrive through Google. They come through events, partners, LinkedIn and the media they already follow. SparkToro shows where those audiences spend their time, so content, partnerships and awards promotion can go where they will be seen.

How we will use it

1. Spend the three free previews on the three audiences hardest to reach through search: international technology companies, innovation institutions and professional firms.
2. List the publications, podcasts and accounts each audience follows, as targets for Insights distribution, PR and partnerships.
3. Note the phrases each audience uses, and check them against the Semrush keyword research.

Limits. The free plan shows preview data only. SparkToro's data comes mostly from the English-language web and social networks, so it says little about audiences on Chinese platforms such as WeChat. For China-based institutions, NEXUS's own partner knowledge will be the better guide.

Paid upgrade. Business, $150/month, gives 25 full reports a month. Worth it only for a dedicated audience research project.

7. Lyssna

Focus area: message clarity · **Cost:** free, 15 responses from people you recruit · lyssna.com

What it is. A user research tool. Its five-second test shows a person a screen for five seconds, then asks them questions about what they remember and understood.

Why NEXUS needs it. The brief's first goal for the home page is to "explain NEXUS in five seconds". A five-second test measures that directly, before launch, using the prototype. It is quicker and cheaper to fix a headline now than after launch.

How we will use it

1. Upload screenshots of the home page hero and the three audience page heroes from the prototype.
2. Ask three questions: What does this company do? Who is it for? What would you click first?
3. Send the link to 5 to 10 people from NEXUS's network, ideally one or two from each audience. Lyssna recommends 5 to 10 participants for this kind of test.

4. Read the answers as a group, and adjust the headlines or intro copy wherever people misread the offer.

Limits. The free plan includes 3 seats and 15 responses from people you recruit yourself, so it suits one round of testing with the home page as the priority. Recruiting from Lyssna's paid participant panel costs extra.

Paid upgrade. Growth, $166/month, removes the response limit for your own participants. Not needed for one round of testing.

8. Microsoft Clarity

Focus area: visitor behaviour · **Cost:** free, with no traffic limit · clarity.microsoft.com

What it is. Microsoft's free behaviour analytics tool. It records anonymised sessions and builds heatmaps showing where visitors click, how far they scroll, and where they get stuck. Built-in AI summarises patterns across sessions and answers questions about the data.

Why NEXUS needs it. Google Analytics shows *that* a visitor left a page. Clarity shows *why*: the headline they skipped, the logo they tried to click, the form field where they gave up. The approved home page has 15 sections, so we also need to know how far down visitors actually get.

What it shows

- **Heatmaps:** click and scroll maps for each page, with AI summaries.
- **Session recordings:** individual visits played back, with key moments highlighted.
- **Frustration signals:** repeated clicks on the same spot, clicks that do nothing, and quick returns to the previous page.
- **AI visibility:** how AI services cite NEXUS content and how AI crawlers visit the site.

How we will use it

1. Install it behind the cookie banner. Since 31 October 2025, Clarity requires a valid consent signal for visitors from the UK, the EEA and Switzerland. Without consent it sets no cookies and collects only limited data.
2. Keep form fields and personal data masked in recordings.
3. Each week after launch, review the home and audience page heatmaps, and watch recordings of visits that started a form but didn't finish it.
4. Report the top three usability fixes each month.

Limits. Data comes only from visitors who accept cookies, and with low early traffic, patterns take a few weeks to emerge. Clarity offers its own connection for AI assistants, so its data can also be analysed with Claude. Source: Microsoft Learn, consent

management.

9. Google Analytics 4

Focus area: enquiry and conversion tracking · **Cost:** free · analytics.google.com

What it is. Google's standard web analytics: who visits, where they came from, which pages they view, and which actions they take.

Why NEXUS needs it. Your brief measures success by qualified enquiries, not traffic, and names the analytics events to track. Google Analytics 4 turns those events into conversion rates for each audience page and each traffic source.

What we will measure

Measure	What it means
Primary conversions	Partnership calls, diagnostic requests and sponsor pack requests, marked as key events
Other conversions	Delegation interest, event interest, general enquiries, report requests
Conversion rate per audience page	Enquiries divided by visits to that page
Form start to submit	How many people who begin a form finish it. We recommend adding a `form_start` event, which the brief doesn't list
Engagement rate	Share of visits lasting over 10 seconds, viewing 2 or more pages, or leading to a conversion
Bounce rate	The share of visits that are not engaged (100% minus the engagement rate)
Home page route-through	Share of home page visits that click through to an audience page: the "five seconds" goal in practice
Traffic sources	Search, AI assistants, LinkedIn, referrals, campaigns tagged with UTM codes

How we will use it

1. Set up all events from the brief through Google Tag Manager, loading only after cookie consent.
2. Check each event fires once per action using DebugView before launch.

3. Build a funnel for each audience: landing page, audience page, form start, form submitted.
4. Link it to Search Console, and set data retention to the 14-month maximum.
5. Report monthly through a free Looker Studio dashboard.

Limits. Google Analytics doesn't work reliably in mainland China, and it only counts visitors who accept cookies. Many institutions visit from China, so the source details saved with every form submission will be the most complete record of where enquiries come from.

10. PageSpeed Insights (Lighthouse)

Focus area: speed and accessibility · **Cost:** free · pagespeed.web.dev

What it is. Google's page testing tool. It runs Lighthouse, which scores a page out of 100 for performance, accessibility, best practice and SEO, and lists what to fix. Where a site has enough visitors, it also shows real-world speed data from Chrome users.

Why NEXUS needs it. Your brief's sign-off checks are written in Lighthouse terms, so this is how we will prove the site passes:

Check	Target
Mobile performance score, Home and audience pages	85 or more
Accessibility score, every page template	95 or more
Largest Contentful Paint (main content loaded)	Under 2.5 seconds
Interaction to Next Paint (response to a tap or click)	Under 200 milliseconds
Cumulative Layout Shift (page jumping while loading)	Under 0.1

How we will use it

1. Test every page template on mobile during the build, using Lighthouse in Chrome while staging is password-protected.
2. Fix every issue that pulls a template below target.
3. Re-test the live pages on launch day, and save the reports as acceptance evidence.
4. Re-test monthly, and after any major content change.

Alongside it. The free axe DevTools browser extension finds accessibility errors Lighthouse can miss. A mainland China speed test confirms that Home and the Asia corridor page load in under 5 seconds from China, as your brief requires.

Limits. A new site won't have enough visitors for real-world speed data at first, so early results are lab tests.

Supporting tools, paid options and connections

Supporting free tools

Tool	What we use it for
Google Tag Manager	Setting up the analytics events and linking them to cookie consent
Looker Studio	The monthly dashboard: conversions by type, conversion rate per audience page, top pages and channels, search terms
Rich Results Test and Schema.org validator	Checking the structured data that describes NEXUS, its services, events and articles to search engines
axe DevTools (browser extension)	Accessibility checks beyond Lighthouse
A mainland China speed test	Load times from inside China before launch

Optional paid tools

None of these is needed for launch. Prices were checked on 31 October 2026, in US dollars unless stated, excluding VAT.

Tool	What it adds	Price
Ahrefs Lite	Competitor research, rank tracking, AI prompt checks	$129/month
Semrush SEO	Keyword and competitor research without the daily cap	$139/month, or $117.33/month billed yearly
Ubersuggest	Lower-cost keyword research and site audits	$29 to $99/month
Similarweb	Competitor traffic estimates	Price on request

Tool	What it adds	Price
Matomo	Privacy-first analytics that can measure visitors in mainland China	Self-hosted edition free; Cloud from 29/month excluding tax
AnswerThePublic	Questions people search for, for FAQs and Insights	From $20/month
Screaming Frog licence	Crawls above 500 URLs, saved crawls	£199/year
SparkToro Business	25 full audience reports a month	$150/month
Lyssna Growth	Unlimited self-recruited responses	$166/month

If you add one paid tool, we suggest Ahrefs Lite for the first three months after launch, about $387 in total.

Working with Claude

We use Claude to analyse the data from these tools and turn it into recommendations. Ahrefs, Semrush, Ubersuggest and Similarweb connect to Claude directly, though they need an account and, for Ahrefs and Similarweb, a paid plan. Clarity also offers a direct connection. For Search Console, Google Analytics, Bing Webmaster Tools and PageSpeed Insights, we export reports and analyse them with Claude.

Sources

Ahrefs pricing · Ahrefs Webmaster Tools · Semrush pricing · Screaming Frog SEO Spider · Screaming Frog licence · SparkToro pricing · Lyssna pricing · Lyssna five-second testing · Microsoft Clarity · Clarity consent management · Bing AI Performance report (Practical Ecommerce) · Ubersuggest pricing · Similarweb pricing · Matomo pricing · AnswerThePublic pricing